unfortunate that with BJP conspiracy, the central government has landed the Matua brothers and sisters into an uncertain and confusing situation. It has been playing politics with the community in the name of granting them citizenship," says Mamata.

Recognising a severe 'trust deficit' between the state and the ECI, the SC transferred control of the adjudication process to the judiciary. Over 500 serving and retired judicial officers from West Bengal, Jharkhand and Odisha were initially deployed to verify documents like Aadhaar and ration cards; their strength has now gone up to 630. Those cleared will be added back via continuous supplementary voter lists, to be published right up to nomination day.

ECI sources say a significant share of the 'doubtful' electors may be suspected illegal migrants from Bangladesh. In Assam, thousands of such 'D' voters—barred from voting since 1997—have had their cases pending for years before Foreigners' Tribunals (FT). Voting rights are restored only if citizenship is confirmed; those declared foreigners face detention and deportation proceedings. In Bengal, judicially appointed officers will now undertake a similar scrutiny under the SIR framework.

WHY THE 35.4 MN DELETIONS

From November 4, 2025, the second phase of the SIR exercise was conducted in nine states and three Union Territories, including poll-bound West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala. Cumulatively, the net deletion stood at approximately 35.4 million voters, or 8.3 per cent of the electors.

The ECI's stated rationale behind the exercise, slated to expand nationwide from April onward, was administrative hygiene. It sought to purify the rolls by removing 'ghost voters' (the deceased, permanently shifted and duplicate entries), digitally modernise the database and correct logical discrepancies. India has not had a nationwide intensive, house-to-house revision since 2002-04. Two decades of migration, urbanisation, deaths and possible foreign-national inclusions had bloated rolls. "The SIR exercise was started to include all the eligible electors in the electoral rolls while ineligible electors, including foreigners, should be excluded from it," says chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.



"IT'S UNFORTUNATE THAT WITH BJP CONSPIRACY, THE GOVERNMENT HAS LANDED THE MATUAS INTO THIS UNCERTAINTY, PLAYING POLITICS IN THE NAME OF GRANTING THEM CITIZENSHIP"

MAMATA BANERJEE
Chief Minister, West Bengal



"THE SIR EXERCISE WAS STARTED TO INCLUDE ALL THE ELIGIBLE ELECTORS IN THE ELECTORAL ROLLS WHILE INELIGIBLE ELECTORS, INCLUDING FOREIGNERS, SHOULD BE EXCLUDED FROM IT"

GYANESH KUMAR
Chief Election Commissioner

Ordered under Article 324 and Section 21 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, the SIR structurally followed a three-step model: freezing the reference roll, conducting enumeration through mandatory form submission and house-to-house verification by booth level officers (BLOs), publishing a draft roll and finally issuing a final roll.

TRUST DEFICIT

The SIR faced fierce backlash. Critics and Opposition leaders argued that the exercise served as a backdoor 'citizenship test'. Activists slammed the ECI for shifting the burden of proof onto the citizen, using rigid algorithmic filters that penalised rural and marginalised voters for natural data variations like rounded-off ages or spelling errors. Long-time voters suddenly had to produce 2002-era documents or face deletion. Women changing names after marriage, migrant workers, the poor and minorities were disproportionately affected. With large 'under adjudication' concentrations reported in specific districts and narratives around migrants/ minorities, the political allegation hardened: roll revision was being used as a selective instrument of electoral engineering.

On its part, the ECI maintained that every deletion followed statutory notice and hearing; parties were given booth-wise data; the SC itself repeatedly endorsed the exercise while only tweaking procedures for transparency and access. In Bihar, zero appeals against deletions were recorded. In fact, the state's electoral experience counters the voter-deletion narrative. Despite a 4.6 per cent roll reduction, voter turnout in the 2025 assembly poll rose compared to the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, suggesting that many deletions involved deceased, duplicate or permanently shifted electors rather than active voters.

The high deletion rates in states like Tamil Nadu and Gujarat, the ECI claims, merely reflected the purging of transient migrant labour who had failed to update their residency. In border states such as West Bengal, the ECI claimed the exercise was necessary to correct years of demographic manipulation and illegal immigration. They asserted that 'zero eligible citizens' would ultimately be left out.

However, despite the ECI's justification, there is no denying that algorithmic filters, in some cases, flagged routine demographic variations as suspect and centralised supervision eroded trust, turning Bengal into a franchise crisis requiring judicial oversight. ■